

An Analysis of Christological Foreshadowing in Abrahamic and Selected Non-Abrahamic Scriptures

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September 18, 2025

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Abstract

This paper conducts a comparative textual analysis of Christological foreshadowing within the foundational scriptures of the Abrahamic faiths—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—and extends this inquiry to identify prophetic parallels in selected non-Abrahamic religious traditions. The primary investigation examines key prophecies and typological symbols in the Hebrew Bible (Tanakh), focusing on Messianic predictions in the Torah, Psalms, and prophetic books concerning the Messiah's lineage, virgin birth, ministry, vicarious suffering, and crucifixion. These prophetic threads are traced to their cited fulfillment in the New Testament. The study then provides a comparative analysis of the Quranic portrayal of Jesus (Isa), highlighting theological convergences, such as the virgin birth and an eschatological role, alongside fundamental divergences, particularly concerning his divine nature and crucifixion. Further, the paper broadens its scope to explore archetypal echoes of a sacrificial redeemer in non-Abrahamic texts, such as the Vedic figure of Prajāpati and the Zoroastrian Saoshyant, framing these as potential instances of universal spiritual anticipation. By synthesizing these diverse textual traditions, the objective is to present a coherent, multi-faceted academic exploration of how the person and work of Jesus Christ are anticipated, depicted, and paralleled across a spectrum of major world scriptures.

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1 Introduction

The figure of Jesus of Nazareth, central to Christianity as the Christ or Messiah, is arguably one of the most influential in human history. Christian theology posits that his life, death, and resurrection were not historical accidents but the culmination of a divine plan foreshadowed for centuries in the sacred scriptures of Israel. This concept of prophecy and fulfillment forms the theological bridge between the Old and New Testaments and is a cornerstone of the Christian faith. The Hebrew Bible, known to Christians as the Old Testament, is replete with passages that Christian exegetes interpret as direct prophecies, typologies, and foreshadowings of Jesus Christ.

This paper seeks to explore the depth and breadth of this prophetic foreshadowing through a primary research question: How do the sacred texts of the Old Testament, alongside parallel and contrasting portrayals in the Quran and other major religious scriptures, anticipate the person and work of Jesus Christ? To answer this, the investigation will analyze specific prophecies related to his lineage, birth, life, suffering, and death, comparing these accounts with their theological treatment in Islam and their archetypal echoes in other traditions.

The methodology employed is primarily a comparative textual analysis. We will first examine key passages from the Hebrew Bible, providing an explanation of their prophetic significance as interpreted in Christian theology. Subsequently, we will turn to the Quran to understand its distinct yet related perspective on Jesus (Isa). Finally, we will broaden the inquiry to identify thematic parallels in selected non-Abrahamic scriptures. This paper is structured to first establish the prophetic foundation in the Old Testament, then explore the Islamic perspective, engage with theological debates, and conclude by considering the universal nature of these redemptive themes.

2 Textual Analysis of Prophecies in the Hebrew Bible

The Hebrew Bible, or Tanakh, is a rich tapestry of law, history, poetry, and prophecy. Within this collection, Christian theology identifies a consistent thread of Messianic prophecy that anticipates a future redeemer. This section will analyze some of the most prominent of these foreshadowings, categorized by theme.

2.1 The Messiah's Lineage and Birth

Christian interpretation identifies numerous prophecies specifying the Messiah's ancestry and the circumstances of his birth. Foundational texts predict a lineage tracing back to Abraham, the tribe of Judah, and the house of King David. The "Protoevangelium" in Genesis 3:15 is often cited as the first promise of a redeemer—the "seed of the

woman”—who would ultimately triumph over evil. More specific genealogical prophecies include Genesis 49:10 (“The scepter shall not depart from Judah...”) and the divine promise made to King David that a descendant from his line would establish an eternal kingdom (2 Samuel 7:12–16).

Two of the most specific prophecies regarding the Messiah’s arrival concern the nature and location of his birth.

The Virgin Birth. The prophet Isaiah, writing circa 700 B.C., delivered a prophecy that has become central to the Christian nativity narrative:

Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign: The virgin will conceive and give birth to a son, and will call him Immanuel. (Isaiah 7:14, NIV) [1]

The Hebrew word used here, *almah*, translates to “young woman,” but the translators of the Septuagint (the Greek version of the Hebrew Bible) chose the Greek word *parthenos*, which specifically means “virgin.” This interpretation is carried into the New Testament, where Matthew’s Gospel explicitly cites this verse as being fulfilled in the miraculous conception of Jesus (Matthew 1:22–23).

The Birthplace in Bethlehem. The prophet Micah provided a remarkably specific prophecy regarding the Messiah’s birthplace:

But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though you are small among the clans of Judah, out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel, whose origins are from of old, from ancient times. (Micah 5:2, NIV) [1]

This prophecy is significant not only for its geographical precision but also for its theological depth, suggesting the ruler’s pre-existence (“from of old, from ancient times”). The New Testament gospels of Matthew and Luke record Jesus’s birth in Bethlehem as a direct fulfillment of this prophecy, despite his parents residing in Nazareth (Matthew 2:1–6; Luke 2:4–7). Another related prophecy, from Jeremiah 31:15 (“Rachel weeping for her children”), is cited in Matthew 2:17–18 as foretelling the massacre of infants in Bethlehem.

2.2 The Suffering Servant: Rejection and Atoning Death

Perhaps the most detailed foreshadowings concern the Messiah’s suffering, rejection, and vicarious death. These themes are powerfully articulated in the Psalms and the book of Isaiah, painting a portrait of a redeemer who saves through suffering.

Psalm 22: A Prefiguration of the Crucifixion. This psalm, attributed to King David, contains a startlingly graphic depiction of crucifixion—a method of execution not practiced by the Jews of that era but later perfected by the Romans. The opening words are famously echoed by Jesus on the cross:

My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? [...] I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint. My heart has turned to wax; it has melted within me. [...] They divide my clothes among them and cast lots for my garment. (Psalm 22:1, 14, 18, NIV) [1]

Each of these details—the cry of dereliction, the description of physical agony akin to dislocation, and the dividing of garments—is recorded in the New Testament accounts of Jesus’s crucifixion (Matthew 27:46; John 19:23–24). Further details, such as the offering of vinegar for thirst (Psalm 69:21) and the promise that none of his bones would be broken (Psalm 34:20), are also cited as fulfilled in John 19.

Isaiah 53: The Man of Sorrows. The 53rd chapter of Isaiah presents the “Suffering Servant,” a figure whose suffering is substitutionary and redemptive:

He was despised and rejected by mankind, a man of suffering, and familiar with pain. [...] Surely he took up our pain and bore our suffering, yet we considered him punished by God, stricken by him, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed. (Isaiah 53:3-5, NIV) [1]

Christian interpretation sees this as a direct prophecy of Jesus’s passion. The themes of rejection, substitutionary atonement (“pierced for our transgressions”), and ultimate healing through his suffering are central tenets of Christian soteriology. This is reinforced by Zechariah 12:10, which states, “They will look on me, the one they have pierced.”

2.3 The Messiah’s Ministry and Triumphal Entry

Prophecy was not limited to verbal predictions but also included symbolic acts and typologies. The Messiah’s public ministry and his final entry into Jerusalem are prominent examples. Isaiah prophesied a humble yet powerful ministry: he would be a “light for the Gentiles” (Isaiah 49:6) and would “bring forth justice to the nations” (Isaiah 42:1-4). Jesus himself claimed the fulfillment of Isaiah 61:1-2 in Luke 4:18-19, defining his mission as proclaiming good news to the poor and freedom for the captives.

A particularly vivid prophecy from Zechariah foretold his arrival in Jerusalem:

Rejoice greatly, Daughter Zion! Shout, Daughter Jerusalem! See, your king comes to you, righteous and victorious, lowly and riding on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey. (Zechariah 9:9, NIV) [1]

In the ancient Near East, a king riding a horse symbolized war, while a king on a donkey symbolized peace. This prophecy foretells a king who would come in peace and humility. All four Gospels record the fulfillment of this prophecy during Jesus's Triumphal Entry into Jerusalem, where he rides a donkey and is greeted by crowds, an act symbolizing victory and reverence (Matthew 21:1–11).

3 The Quranic Perspective on Jesus (Isa)

The Quran honors Jesus, or Isa ibn Maryam (Jesus, son of Mary), as one of God's mightiest prophets. While Islamic theology differs fundamentally from Christianity on the divinity of Jesus, the Quran affirms several key aspects of his life that align with Old Testament prophecy and New Testament accounts, while also presenting unique theological claims.

3.1 Affirmation of the Virgin Birth and Miracles

The Quran explicitly and repeatedly affirms the virgin birth of Jesus, presenting it as a sign of God's absolute power. The narrative in Surah Maryam (Chapter 19) describes the annunciation by the angel Gabriel to Mary (Maryam):

She said: "How shall I have a son, seeing that no man has touched me, and I am not unchaste?" He said: "So (it will be): Thy Lord saith, 'that is easy for Me: and (We wish) to appoint him as a Sign unto men and a Mercy from Us': It is a matter (so) decreed." (Quran 19:20-21) [2]

This miraculous conception resonates with the sign offered in Isaiah 7:14. Furthermore, the Quran recounts numerous miracles performed by Jesus, including speaking from the cradle, healing the blind and lepers, and raising the dead—all by God's permission (Surah 5:110). These acts distinguish him among the prophets and underscore his extraordinary status.

3.2 Eschatological Role and Unique Titles

A significant aspect of Islamic eschatology is the belief in the second coming of Jesus before the Day of Judgment (Yawm al-Qiyamah). The Quran states:

And (Jesus) shall be a Sign (for the coming of) the Hour (of Judgment): therefore have no doubt about the (Hour), but follow ye Me: this is a Straight Way. (Quran 43:61) [2]

In Islamic tradition (Hadith), Jesus will return to Earth, defeat the Antichrist (Al-Masih ad-Dajjal), and establish justice as a "just judge" (*hakam 'adl*) [3]. This role as a figure of ultimate justice leads to a point of profound theological discussion, as Islamic doctrine is adamant that only Allah is the ultimate judge. Islamic scholars typically resolve this by explaining that Jesus will judge according to the law of the Quran, acting as an agent of Allah's judgment, not as an independent divine authority.

Further setting him apart, the Quran grants Jesus titles not given to other prophets, such as **Kalimatullah** (the Word of God) and **Ruhullah** (a Spirit from God) (Surah 3:45, 4:171). From a Christian perspective, these titles—especially "Word of God"—align with the concept of the divine Logos described in the Gospel of John (John 1:1) and suggest a unique ontological connection to God. While Islam interprets these titles as honorifics affirming his prophetic role, their uniqueness creates a subtle theological tension, as they attribute to Jesus qualities consistent with divinity in Judeo-Christian thought.

4 Comparative Theological Discussion

The prophetic foreshadowing of Jesus Christ provides a powerful framework for the Christian narrative of salvation, but it is also a point of significant theological divergence among the Abrahamic faiths.

4.1 Jewish Objections and Christian Responses

For Jewish scholarship, the Messianic prophecies of the Hebrew Bible are interpreted differently. The "suffering servant" in Isaiah 53 is often understood as a personification of the nation of Israel in exile, not an individual Messiah. Similarly, prophecies of a Messianic age are expected to involve the restoration of the nation of Israel, universal peace, and the physical rebuilding of the Temple in Jerusalem. Since these expectations were not met during the lifetime of Jesus, traditional Jewish teaching maintains that the Messiah has not yet appeared.

A frequently cited argument involves Jesus' statement: "Destroy this temple, and I will raise it again in three days" (John 2:19). Jewish interpretation often reads this literally, arguing that the Messiah must physically reconstruct the Temple. Christian interpretation, however, understands Jesus' words as a metaphor for his own body, which would be crucified and resurrected. This metaphorical reading is supported by the tearing of the Temple veil at his death (Matthew 27:51), symbolizing the inauguration of a new covenant where access to God is no longer limited by a physical structure. From a Christian perspective, no other historical figure has satisfied the comprehensive range of Messianic prophecies, which include details of birth, ministry, suffering, and resurrection, suggesting that Jesus uniquely embodies the Messianic role both historically and

spiritually.

4.2 Convergence and Divergence in Abrahamic Christology

The inclusion of the Quranic perspective adds another layer of complexity. Islam accepts the prophetic mantle of Jesus, his virgin birth, and his role in the end times, thereby validating core aspects of his supernatural identity. However, it vehemently rejects his divinity and crucifixion (Quran 4:157), creating a theological position that is both connected to and distinct from the Judeo-Christian tradition. The subtle tension surrounding his role as a "judge" in Islamic eschatology underscores the profound theological questions his figure raises across all three Abrahamic religions. Is he a prophet, a divine king, a suffering servant, or a sign of the final judgment? The scriptures provide material for all these interpretations, yet they remain distinct.

5 Prophetic Parallels in Non-Abrahamic Traditions

While direct prophecy concerning Jesus is unique to the Judeo-Christian scriptures, certain non-Abrahamic texts contain profound symbolism that parallels the person and atoning work of the Messiah. These themes can be interpreted as a universal spiritual longing for a redeemer, a concept sometimes termed *praeparatio evangelica* (evangelical preparation).

5.1 The Sacrificial Creator: Prajāpati in Vedic Scripture

One of the most striking parallels is found in the Vedic accounts of Prajāpati, the "Lord of Creatures," whose self-sacrifice is described as the basis for creation and redemption. The Shatapatha Brahmana states that Prajāpati offered himself to redeem his creation from disorder. Furthermore, Vedic sacrificial rituals required the offering to be bound to a wooden post, the *yūpa*, a powerful symbol that resonates with the cross. The Purusha Sukta (Rig Veda 10.90) describes the primordial Purusha (Cosmic Man) being sacrificed, with his body forming the basis of the cosmos. This concept of a perfect, primordial sacrifice by a divine being for the sake of creation provides a profound parallel to the Christian doctrine of atonement through the "lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Peter 1:19).

5.2 The Future Redeemer in Other Traditions

Similar archetypes of a savior figure appear in other major world religions.

- **Zoroastrianism:** The ancient religion of Persia proclaims the coming of a savior known as *Saoshyant* ("one who brings benefit"). He is prophesied to be born of

a virgin, lead humanity in a final battle against evil (*Angra Mainyu*), and bring about a final resurrection and restoration of the world.

- **Hinduism:** Beyond Prajāpati, Hindu eschatology anticipates the coming of *Kalki*, the final avatar of Vishnu, who will appear at the end of the current age (Kali Yuga) to destroy unrighteousness and re-establish dharma (cosmic order). His mission as a savior and judge mirrors Christ's eschatological role.

Across these diverse traditions, one finds recurring motifs: a divinely guided figure, often born of extraordinary circumstances, whose life embodies moral perfection and whose mission is to overcome evil and restore order. While the theological frameworks differ, these archetypal echoes suggest that the anticipation of a messianic savior is a near-universal motif in human spirituality.

6 Conclusion

The textual evidence from the Hebrew Bible presents a detailed and multi-faceted portrait of a promised Messiah. From the place of his birth to the manner of his death, these ancient texts contain a remarkable collection of foreshadowings that, according to Christian belief, find their complete fulfillment in the person of Jesus Christ. The symbolism of his ministry and the theology of his suffering are laid out with a clarity that Christians argue can only be of divine origin.

The Quran, while diverging on the core issues of divinity and crucifixion, corroborates foundational elements of Jesus's miraculous existence and confirms his significance in the divine plan for humanity's end. This shared prophetic heritage, despite different interpretations, consistently elevates the figure of Jesus. Finally, the archetypal parallels found in non-Abrahamic traditions, such as the Vedic Prajāpati and the Zoroastrian Saoshyant, suggest a universal spiritual anticipation of a divine redeemer.

This analysis has demonstrated that whether viewed as the divine Son of God, a great prophet, or a suffering servant, the figure of Jesus of Nazareth is deeply embedded in the sacred textual traditions of the world. The prophetic foreshadowing is not merely a collection of disparate predictions but forms a coherent narrative that spans centuries, scriptures, and cultures, pointing toward a singular, transformative figure in human history.

References

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